

The Concept of India and Indian Secularism According to Romila Thapar and Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak

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Abstract

This article examines the concept of India and Indian Secularism through the intellectual framework of the famous historian Romila Thapar and postcolonial theorist Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak. Thapar's historical analysis proves that the very concept of India is the product of an evolutionary pluralism. She emphasizes that secularism is a socio-political necessity for the coexistence of the diverse belief systems and cultures which is the core of Indian psyche. Thapar states that secularism is deeply rooted in the harmonious blend of the various rich traditions of India. Gayatri Spivak the famous oriental critique uses deconstruction and subaltern studies to point out that the nationalist discourses that silence the marginalised voices is a kind of epistemic violence. Spivak emphasizes that diversity of any sort is a vital expression of culture and in no way it should be suppressed. For them India is an evolutionary outcome of the rich pluralist tradition. By synthesizing Thapar's historiography and Spivak's social criticism it is evident that their insights are crucial in today's world to encounter religious extremism and monolithic majoritarianism and diverging historical perspectives. The views of Romila Thapar and Spivak provide a robust defence for a pluralistic national identity that remain inclusive of the marginalised and the deprived classes. Their thinking underlines the fact that the Indian secularism affirms total religious freedom and protects the rights of the minorities. Both Thapar and Spivak explore the intersectionality of gender, minority rights, and the pedagogy of the nation, concluding that the "Idea of India" is a transformative, unfinished and ever evolving project contingent upon the ethical and moral recognition of its internal others and the rigorous defence of historical truth and perennial facts of the past.

Keywords: Concept of India, Indian Secularism, Subaltern, Pluralism, Historiography, Epistemic Violence, Pedagogy, Minorities